

Executive Summary

A Sustainable Sponsorship Model for Medical Trainee Research Fellowships

OVERVIEW

REACH Partnerships Foundation is a pre-launch 501(c)(3) nonprofit designed to support medical trainees pursuing K-level career development awards (K01, K08, K23) through sustainable sponsorship-funded research fellowships.

The foundation addresses a critical gap in the medical training pipeline: early-career researchers lack the preliminary data, mentorship connections, and protected research time needed to successfully compete for federal K-awards that launch independent research careers.

What makes REACH unique is its sustainability mechanism. Rather than relying solely on traditional philanthropy—which is cyclical, competitive, and insufficient to meet demand—REACH generates recurring revenue through real estate relocation referral fees and marketing sponsorships from service providers who benefit from access to the high-earning-potential medical trainee demographic.

THE PROBLEM

NIH K-awards are the primary federal instrument for training physician-scientists. However, K-award applications are intensely competitive—60-80% of applicants receive no funding. The barriers are structural:

- **Limited Protected Research Time:** Clinical training programs leave residents and fellows with minimal time for research. A resident working 60-80 hours per week cannot simultaneously generate preliminary data.
- **The Preliminary Data Paradox:** K-awards require preliminary data demonstrating feasibility—but trainees cannot generate preliminary data without funding. This creates a chicken-and-egg problem.
- **Mentorship Navigation Opacity:** Successful K-awards require strong mentorship teams. However, identifying appropriate mentors is relationship-dependent and opaque, disadvantaging those outside established networks.
- **Career Development Complexity:** K-awards require clear articulation of how proposed projects fit within a trajectory toward R01 independence—institutional knowledge that is unevenly distributed.

OUR SOLUTION

Each REACH fellowship provides \$11,500 in direct funding (administered through Emory) to support a one-year pilot research program aligned with NIH K-award requirements. Fellows complete a structured 12-question framework that systematically addresses every component required for competitive K-award applications.

The REACH model creates a virtuous cycle:

1. Medical trainees receive research funding and relocation support
2. Sponsors gain marketing access to future high-earning physicians
3. Real estate agents access qualified buyers in transition
4. The foundation generates sustainable revenue that grows with program success

SUSTAINABLE REVENUE MODEL

Medical trainees are among the most mobile professional populations in America. REACH capitalizes on this natural mobility through two complementary revenue streams:

Relocation Referral Fees: When a REACH-affiliated trainee purchases a home through our Keller Williams network, the receiving agent pays a 25% referral fee to REACH—approximately \$3,000 per transaction. This revenue directly funds additional fellowship awards.

Sponsor Partnerships: Service providers who serve relocating professionals (real estate agents, financial advisors, attorneys, insurance agents) pay \$200/month for marketing access to the medical trainee demographic. This creates recurring revenue that supports operations.

THE FELLOWSHIP PROGRAM

Target Population: MD/PhD students, residents, clinical fellows, and early-career faculty pursuing K01, K08, or K23 awards.

Award Amount: \$11,500 per fellow (administered through Emory) for tuition, research supplies, IRB fees, professional development, and related expenses.

Program Components:

- 12-Question K-Award Framework covering all NIH requirements
- Weekly check-in surveys identifying emerging barriers
- Year-end symposium presentation
- Relocation support through vetted service providers

Program Goal: K-award submission within 12-18 months of fellowship completion.

Pilot Location: Emory University, with expansion planned to other Georgia institutions and the Southeast region.

IMPLEMENTATION TIMELINE

Prototype Phase (Nov 2025 - Nov 2026)

3 fellows at Emory, 5 founding sponsors, platform MVP, first referral transactions

Pilot Phase (Nov 2026 - Nov 2027)

10 fellows, 15+ sponsors, 501(c)(3) formation, Georgia expansion planning

Regional Expansion (2027-2028)

Georgia medical schools, Southeast partnerships, first staff hires

National Scale (2028+)

Multi-state presence, institutional partnerships, endowment building

FUNDING OPPORTUNITIES

\$15,000

Fund One Fellowship

Support a single trainee through their K-award preparation year

\$50,000

Fund Prototype Year

3 fellows plus operations for the full proof-of-concept phase

\$150,000

Fund Pilot Year

10 fellows plus 501(c)(3) formation and Georgia expansion

\$2,000,000+

Named Fellowship Endowment

Permanent legacy supporting fellows in perpetuity

Join us in building a sustainable future for physician-scientist training.

reachpartnerships.org